

VNET Group

In-line 2Q, stronger 2027/28 outlook on continued order wins

VNET reported in-line 2Q26 core earnings and hosted an earnings call on 18 Aug. Key takeaways were: (1) 2Q26 adj-EBITDA came in largely in line with Street estimates as stringent opex control offset higher utility costs; (2) management reiterated 2026 revenue/adj-EBITDA guidance of Rmb11.5–11.8bn / Rmb3.55–3.75bn, with a faster customer move-in rate in 2H26 implying 13%/2% HoH growth in revenue/adj-EBITDA at the midpoint; (3) announced new orders of 345MW/2MW from a cloud service wholesale customer and multiple retail customers, respectively; (4) ~862MW order backlogs with 33%/40% targeted delivery in 2026/27, and 355MW of reserved capacity from wholesale customers likely to convert to firm orders over time; (5) a target to deliver 585MW of new capacity over the next 12 months (2H26–1H27), with ~94% pre-commitment rate; and (6) secured ~1.4GW of land bank (~65%/35% domestic/overseas mix) for future customer demand, signaling strong longer-term demand visibility.

J.P. Morgan's views

- While the reiterated full-year guidance implies only mild sequential growth in 3Q/4Q26, we see potential upside from a faster customer move-in rate in 2H26, driven by the ramp-up of domestic chip supply. We also expect robust earnings momentum over the next two years, supported by multi-year large wholesale order wins in recent quarters and fast-growing AI inference demand. We remain OW on VNET on secular earnings growth, a strong wholesale order pipeline, and an undemanding valuation. Stay OW. Key downside risk is slower-than-expected domestic AI ASIC chip adoption.

Overweight

VNET, VNET US
Price (17 Aug 26):\$7.92
Price Target (Jun-27):\$15.00

Technology - Hardware

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Table 1: VNET Group 2Q26 earnings review

CNY million	2Q26			Variance		Growth	
	Actual	JPMe	BBG	vs. JPMe	vs. Consensus	Q/Q	Y/Y
Revenues	2,779	2,746	2,764	1%	1%	3%	14%
Gross profit	505	591	610	-15%	-17%	-18%	-8%
Operating profit	229	171	237	34%	-3%	-7%	33%
EBITDA	913	839	N.A.	9%	N.A.	3%	26%
Adj. EBITDA (ex SBC)	918	850	898	8%	2%	3%	25%
Adj. EBITDA Margin (%)	33.0%	31.0%	32.5%	210 bps	54 bps	-8 bps	296 bps
Pretax profit	18	(44)	70	N.A.	-74%	-56%	-84%
Net profit to common equity	(145)	(114)	(18)	N.A.	N.A.	N.A.	N.A.
Net Margin (%)	-5.2%	-4.1%	-0.7%	N.A.	N.A.	N.A.	N.A.

Source: Company data, Bloomberg Finance L.P., J.P. Morgan estimates.

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Investment Thesis, Valuation and Risks

VNET Group (*Overweight; Price Target: \$15.00*)

Investment Thesis

We see earnings upside for VNET next year driven by new order wins and likely better-than-expected margins due to better product mix, favorable pricing dynamics, and lower unit capex. We anticipate a gradual ROIC improvement in the mid- to longer-term, driven by a healthy pricing trend, lower land costs, and continued product mix improvement. We stay OW on the stock and expect the stock to outperform the index over the next 6-12 months due to robust earnings growth, strong wholesale order pipelines, and an undemanding valuation.

Valuation

Our Jun-27 PT of \$15 is based on ~10x 12m-forward adjusted EBITDA, around the mid-range of previous up-cycle valuations.

Risks to Rating and Price Target

Key upside risks include new wholesale order wins and overseas revenue opportunities. Key downside risks include weaker-than-expected China server spending or supply constraints of domestic China AI chips.

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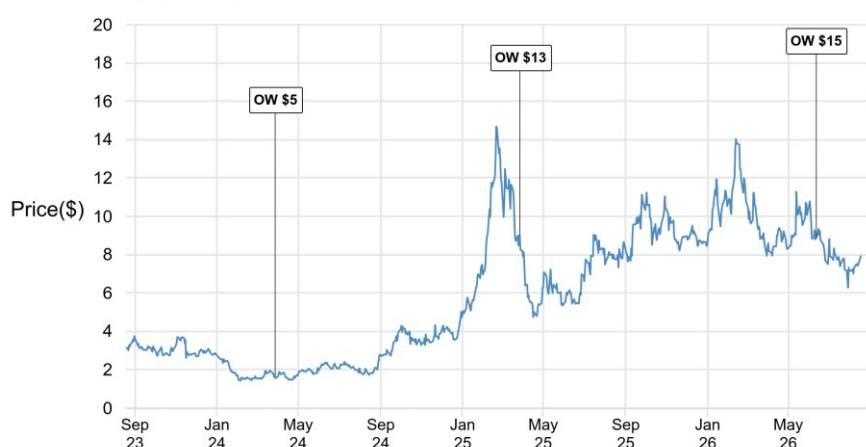
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VNET Group (VNET, VNET US) Price Chart



Date	Rating	Price (\$)	Price Target (\$)
28-Mar-24	OW	1.70	5
28-Mar-25	OW	9.01	13
12-Jun-26	OW	8.95	15

Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Jul 11, 2011. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

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